

VI The Body As Expression, and Speech

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We have discovered in the body a unity distinct from that of the scientific object. We have just discovered, even in the body's "sexual function," an intentionality and a power of signification. By now seeking to describe the phenomenon of speech and the deliberate act of signification, we will have the opportunity to leave behind, once and for all, the classical subject-object dichotomy.

a. Empiricism and intellectualism in the theory of aphasia, equally insufficient.

The recognition of speech as an original region naturally comes late. Here as everywhere, the relation of *having* [*avoir*], which is nevertheless visible in the very etymology of the word "habit" [*habitude*],¹ is at first masked by relations from the domain of *being* [*être*], or, as we might also put it, by intra-worldly and ontic relations.² The possession of language is understood at first as the simple actual existence of "verbal images," that is, of traces left in us by words that were spoken or heard. It is of little importance whether the traces are bodily or are deposited in an "unconscious psyche," and in both cases the conception of language is the same in that there is no "speaking subject." Whether stimuli trigger, according to the laws of the nervous system, the stimulations capable of provoking the articulation of the word, or whether states of consciousness bring about the appearance of the appropriate verbal image in virtue of acquired associations, in both cases speech takes place in a circuit of third person phenomena. There is no one who speaks, there is but a flow of words that occurs without any intention to speak governing it. The sense of the words is assumed to be given with the stimuli or with the states of consciousness to be named; the sonorous or articulatory configuration of the word is given along with the cerebral or psychical traces; speech is not an action, for it does not manifest the inner possibilities of the subject. Man can speak in the way an electric lamp can become incandescent. Since there are selective disorders that attack spoken language to the exclusion of written language, or writing to the exclusion of speech, and since language can be decomposed into fragments, this would be because it is constituted by a series of independent contributions and because speech, in the general sense, is a being that comes from reason.

The theory of aphasia and of language seemed to be completely transformed when it became necessary to distinguish, beyond anarthria³ (which affects word articulation), a true aphasia, which never occurs without some intellectual disorder; and beyond automatic language (which is in fact a motor phenomenon in the third person), an intentional language, the only one affected in the majority of cases of aphasia. The individuality of the "verbal image" was, in effect, dissociated. What the patient had lost, and what the normal person possessed, was not a certain stock of words, but rather a certain manner of using them. The same word that remains available to the patient on the level of automatic language escapes him on the level of spontaneous language; the same patient who easily finds the word "no" to express a negative answer to the doctor's questions, that is, when the word signifies a present and lived negation, cannot pronounce it when engaged in an exercise without any affective or vital importance. Thus, behind the word we discover an attitude or a function of speech that conditions it. The distinction

had to be made between the word as an instrument of action and the word as a means of disinterested denomination. If “concrete” language remained a third person process, then spontaneous language or authentic denomination became a phenomenon of thought, and so the origin of certain types of aphasia had to be sought in some mental disorder. For example, an amnesia of color names, placed back into the overall behavior of the patient, appeared as a particular manifestation of a more general disorder. The same patients who fail to name the colors presented to them are equally incapable of classifying them according to a given rule. For example, if they are asked to sort samples according to their fundamental tint, it is first observed that they perform the task more slowly and more meticulously than a normal subject. They bring the samples together to compare them, and they do not see at a glance which ones “go together.” Moreover, after having correctly assembled several blue ribbons, they commit incomprehensible errors. For example, if the last blue ribbon was of a pale shade, they proceed by adding a pale green or a pale pink ribbon to the “blue” pile – as if it were impossible for them to sustain the proposed principle of classification and of considering the samples from the point of view of color from the beginning to the end of the operation. They have thus become incapable of subsuming the sensory givens under a category and incapable of immediately seeing the samples as representatives of the *eidos* “blue.” Even when they proceed correctly at the beginning of the test, it is not the participation of the samples in a single idea that guides them, but rather the experience of an immediate resemblance, and this is why they can only classify the samples after having brought them together. For these patients, the sorting test reveals a fundamental disorder of which the amnesia of color names will only be another manifestation. For to name an object is to tear oneself away from what its individual and unique properties are in order to see it as the representative of an essence or of a category. And if the patient cannot name the samples, this is not because he has lost the verbal image of the word “red” or the word “blue,” it is because he has lost the general power of subsuming a sensory given under a category, it is because he has fallen back from the categorial attitude into the concrete attitude.⁴ These analyses, and other similar ones, lead us it would seem to the extreme opposite of the theory of verbal images, since language now appears as conditioned by thought.

b. Language has a sense.

In fact, we will see once again that there is a kinship between empirical or mechanistic psychologies and intellectualist psychologies, and the problem of language cannot be solved by going from thesis to antithesis. A moment ago, the reproduction of the word and the awakening of the verbal image was the key; now, the word is no more than the envelope of genuine denomination of authentic speech, which is an inner operation. These two theories, however, concur in the claim that the word *has* no signification. This is clear in the first case since the evocation of the word is not mediated by any concept, and because the stimuli or the given “states of consciousness” call forth the word according to the laws of the nervous system or according to those of association. Hence the word does not bear its sense, it has no inner power, and is nothing more than a psychical, physiological, or even physical phenomenon juxtaposed with others and brought to light through the play of an objective causality. Nothing changes when the denomination is doubled by a categorial operation. The word is again stripped of any efficacy of its own, this time because it is merely the external sign of an inner recognition that could be accomplished

without it and to which it does not contribute. The word is not stripped of sense, since behind it there is a categorial operation, but the word itself does not *have* this sense, it does not possess it. Thought has a sense and the word remains an empty envelope. The word is merely an articulatory, sonorous phenomenon, or the consciousness of this phenomenon, but in any case, language is only an external accompaniment of thought. In the first account, we exist prior to the word as meaningful; in the second account, we are beyond it – in the first, there is no one who speaks; in the second, there is certainly a subject, but it is the thinking subject, not the speaking subject. With regard to speech itself, intellectualism hardly differs from empiricism, and it is no more able to do without an explanation through automatic reflexes. Once the categorial operation has been accomplished, the appearance of the word that accomplishes it remains to be explained, and again an explanation is found through a physiological or psychological mechanism, since the word is an inert envelope. Thus, we move beyond intellectualism as much as empiricism through the simple observation that *the word has a sense*.

c. Language does not presuppose thought, it accomplishes thought.

If speech presupposed thought, or if speaking was primarily the act of connecting with the object through a knowledge intention or through a representation, then we could not understand why thought tends toward expression as if toward its completion, why the most familiar object appears indeterminate so long as we have not remembered its name, and why the thinking subject himself is in a sort of ignorance of his thoughts so long as he has not formulated them for himself, or even spoken or written them, as is shown through the example of so many writers who begin a book without knowing just what they are going to include. A thought, content to exist for itself outside the constraints of speech and communication, would fall into the unconscious the moment it appears, which amounts to saying that it would not even exist for itself. To Kant's famous question, we can respond that it is indeed an experience of thought, in the sense that we give our thought to ourselves through inner or outer speech. It certainly moves forward instantly, as if through flashes, but it subsequently remains for us to appropriate it, and it is through expression that thought becomes our own. The designation of objects never happens after recognition, it is recognition itself. When I focus on an object in the shadows and I say: "It's a brush," there is no concept of the brush in my mind beneath which I could subsume the object and that moreover could be linked with the word "brush" through a frequent association. Rather, the word bears the sense, and, by imposing it upon the object, I am conscious of reaching the object. As has often been said, the object is only known by the child once it has been named; the name is the essence of the object and resides in it, just like its color or its form.⁵ For pre-scientific thought, to name an object is to bring it into existence or to modify it: God creates beings by naming them, and magic affects objects by speaking of them. These "errors" would be incomprehensible if speech was based upon the concept, for the concept would always have to know itself as distinct from speech and to know speech as an external accompaniment. If one responds that the child learns to know objects through the designations of language, that, presented primarily as linguistic beings, objects thereby only receive a natural existence secondarily, and finally that the actual existence of a linguistic community accounts for these childish beliefs, then this explanation leaves the problem intact. For if the child can know himself as a member of a linguistic community prior to knowing himself as a thought about Nature, this is on condition that the

subject can be unaware of himself as a universal thought and can grasp himself as speech, and on condition that the word, far from being the simple sign of objects and significations, inhabits things and bears significations.

For the speaker, then, speech does not translate a ready-made thought; rather, speech accomplishes thought.⁶ Even more so, it must be acknowledged that the person listening receives the thought from the speech itself. At first glance, one might believe that speech that is heard can bring him nothing: he gives the words and the phrases their sense, and even the combination of words and phrases is not some external contribution, since it would not be understood if it did not encounter in him the power of actualizing it. Here as everywhere, it seems true at first glance that consciousness can only find in its experience what it had itself put there. Hence the experience of communication would be an illusion. One consciousness constructs – for X – this language machine that will give to another consciousness the opportunity to enact the same thoughts, but nothing actually passes from one to the other. Nevertheless, given the problem of knowing how according to all appearances consciousness learns something, the solution cannot consist in asserting that it knows everything in advance. The fact is that we have the power to understand beyond what we could have spontaneously thought. People can only speak to us in a language we already know, and each word of a difficult text awakens thoughts in us that belonged to us in advance, but these significations sometimes combine into a new thought that reworks them all, and we are transported to the heart of the book and connect with the source. There is nothing here comparable to the resolution of a problem, where an unknown term is discovered through its relation with known terms. For the problem can only be resolved if it is determinate, that is, if the cross-checking of the givens assigns one or several definite values to the unknown. In understanding others, the problem is always indeterminate⁷ because only the solution to the problem will make the givens retrospectively appear as convergent, and only the central motive of a philosophy, once understood, gives the philosopher's texts the value of adequate signs. Through speech, then, there is a taking up of the other person's thought, a reflection in others, a power of thinking *according to others*,⁸ which enriches our own thoughts. Here, then, the sense of words must ultimately be induced by the words themselves, or more precisely their conceptual signification must be formed by drawing from a *gestural signification*, which itself is immanent in speech. And just as, when in a foreign country, I begin to understand the sense of words by their place in a context of action and by participating in everyday life, so too a philosophical text that remains poorly understood nevertheless reveals to me at least a certain “style” – whether Spinozistic, critical, or phenomenological – which is the first sketch of its sense. I begin to understand a philosophy by slipping into this thought's particular manner of existing, by reproducing the tone or the accent of the philosopher in question. In short, every language teaches itself and imports its meaning [*sens*] into the listener's mind. A piece of music or a painting that is not immediately understood ultimately creates its own public – so long as it truly says something – which is to say, by secreting its own signification. In the case of prose or poetry, the power of speech is less visible because we have the illusion of already possessing within ourselves, with the common meaning of words, what will be necessary for understanding any text whatsoever, whereas, to all appearance, the colors of the palette or the brute sounds of the instruments, such as natural perception presents them to

us, are insufficient to form the musical sense of a piece of music or the pictorial sense of a painting. But in fact, it is less the case that the sense of a literary work is built from the common meanings of the words than that the literary work contributes to modifying that common meaning. There is, then, either for the person listening or reading, or for the person speaking or writing, a *thought in the speech* of which intellectualism is wholly unaware.

d. Thought in words.

If we wish to give an account of this, we must return to the phenomenon of speech and question the usual descriptions that congeal both thought and speech, and that make anything other than external relations between them inconceivable. We must first recognize that, for the speaking subject, thought is not a representation; that is, thought does not explicitly posit objects or relations. The orator does not think prior to speaking, nor even while speaking; his speech is his thought. The listener similarly does not think about the signs. The “thought” of the orator is empty while he speaks and, when a text is read in front of us, and if the expression is successful, we do not have a thought on the margins of the text itself. The words occupy our entire mind, they come to fulfill our expectation exactly, and we experience the necessity of the speech [*discours*]; but we would not have been capable of predicting it, and we are possessed by it. The end of the speech or of the text will be the lifting of a spell. It is then that thoughts about the speech or the text will be able to arise. Previously the speech was improvised and the text was understood without a single thought; the sense was present everywhere, but nowhere was it posited for itself. If the speaking subject does not conceive of the sense of what he says, he no more represents to himself the words he employs. As we have said, knowing a word or a language [*langue*] does not consist in having available some preestablished neural arrangements. But for all that, neither is it the preservation of some “pure memory” or some weakened perception of the word. The Bergsonian alternative between habit-memory and pure memory does not account for the near presence of the words that I know. They are behind me, like the objects behind my back or like the horizon of the village surrounding my house; I reckon with them or I count upon them, but I have no “verbal image” of them. If they persist in me, they do so more in the manner of the Freudian *Imago*, which is much less the representation of a previous perception than a very precise and very general emotional essence detached from its empirical origins. What remains for me of the word I have learned is its sonorous and articulatory style. We must say of the verbal image what we said above of the “representation of movement”: I have no need of representing to myself external space and my own body in order to move the one within the other. It is enough that they exist for me and that they constitute a certain field of action held around me. Likewise, I have no need of representing to myself the word in order to know it and to pronounce it. It is enough that I possess its articulatory and sonorous essence as one of the modulations or one of the possible uses of my body. I relate to the word just as my hand reaches for the place on my body being stung. The word has a certain place in my linguistic world, it is a part of my equipment. The only means I have of representing it to myself is by pronouncing it, just as the only means the artist has of representing to himself the work he is pursuing is by producing it. When I imagine absent Pierre, I am not conscious of contemplating Pierre in an image numerically distinct from Pierre himself. As far away as Pierre might be, I aim at him in the world, and my power of imagining is

nothing other than the persistence of my world around me.⁹ To say that I imagine Pierre is to say that I obtain a pseudo-presence of Pierre by triggering the “Pierre-behavior.” Just as imagined Pierre is only one of the modalities of my being in the world, the verbal image too is only one of the modalities of my phonetic gesticulation, given with many others in the overall consciousness of my body. This is clearly what Bergson means when he speaks of a “motor structure” of recollection,¹⁰ but if these pure representations of the past come to insert themselves into this structure, then it is not clear why they would have need of it in order to become actual again. The role of the body in memory can only be understood if memory is not the constituting consciousness of the past, but rather an effort to reopen time beginning from the implications of the present, and if the body, being our permanent means of “adopting attitudes” and hence of creating pseudo-presents, is the means of our communication with both time and space.¹¹ The function of the body in memory is that very function of projection that we have already encountered in kinetic initiation: the body converts a certain motor essence into a vocalization, deploys the articulatory style of a word in sonorous phenomena, deploys the previous attitude that it takes up in the panorama of the past, and projects an intention to move into actual movement, all because the body is a natural power of expression.

e. Thought is expression.

These remarks allow us to give the act of speaking its true physiognomy. First, speech is not the “sign” of thought, if by this we understand a phenomenon that announces another as smoke announces fire. Speech and thought would only admit of this external relation if they were both thematically given; in fact, they are enveloped in each other; sense is caught in speech, and speech is the external existence of sense. We can no more admit, as is ordinarily done, that speech is a simple means of solidifying thought, or again, that it is the envelope or the clothing of thought. If the so-called verbal images need to be reconstructed each time, why would it be easier to recall words or phrases than to recall thoughts? And why would thought seek to double itself or to clothe itself in a series of vocalizations, if the latter do not carry and do not contain their sense in themselves? Words can only be the “fortresses of thought” and thought can only seek expression if the words are by themselves a comprehensible text and if speech possesses a power of signification of its own. In one way or another, the word and speech must cease to be a manner of designating the object or the thought in order to become the presence of this thought in the sensible world, and not its clothing, but rather its emblem or its body. There must be, as the psychologists say, a “linguistic concept” (*Sprachbegriff*)¹² or a verbal concept (*Wortbegriff*), a “central internal experience, specifically verbal, thanks to which the sound heard, pronounced, read, or written becomes a fact of language.”¹³ Some patients can read a text “expressively” despite not understanding it. This is because speech or words carry a primary layer of signification that adheres to them and that gives the thought as a style, as an affective value, or as an existential mimicry, rather than as a conceptual statement. We discover here, beneath the conceptual signification of words, an existential signification that is not simply translated by them, but that inhabits them and is inseparable from them. The most important achievement of expression is not to commit to writing some thoughts that might otherwise be lost; a writer hardly ever rereads his own works and, on the first reading, a great work deposits in us

everything that we will subsequently draw from it. The operation of expression, when successful, does not simply leave to the reader or the writer himself a reminder; it makes the signification exist as a thing at the very heart of the text, it brings it to life in an organism of words, it installs this signification in the writer or the reader like a new sense organ, and it opens a new field or a new dimension to our experience.

This power of expression is well known in art, for example in music. The musical signification of the sonata is inseparable from the sounds that carry it: prior to having heard it, no analysis allows us to anticipate it. Once the performance has come to an end, we cannot do anything in our intellectual analyses of the music but refer back to the moment of the experience. During the performance, the sounds are not merely the “signs” of the sonata; rather, the sonata is there through them and it descends into them.¹⁴ Likewise, the actress becomes invisible, and it is Phaedra who appears. The signification absorbs the signs, and Phaedra has so fully taken possession of Berma that her ecstasy in Phaedra seems to us to be the pinnacle of naturalness and of facility.¹⁵ Aesthetic expression confers an existence in itself upon what it expresses, installs it in nature as a perceived thing accessible to everyone, or inversely rips the signs themselves – the actor's person, the painter's colors and canvas – from their empirical existence and steals them away to another world. No one will object that here the expressive operation actualizes or accomplishes the signification and is not merely a matter of translating it. But despite appearances, the same is true for the expression of thoughts by speech. Thought is nothing “inner,” nor does it exist outside the world and outside of words. What tricks us here, what makes us believe in a thought that could exist for itself prior to expression, are the already constituted and already expressed thoughts that we can silently recall to ourselves and by which we give ourselves the illusion of an inner life. But in fact, this supposed silence is buzzing with words – this inner life is an inner language. “Pure” thought is reduced to a certain emptiness of consciousness and to an instantaneous desire. The new meaningful intention only knows itself by donning already available significations, which are the results of previous acts of expression. The available significations suddenly intertwine according to an unknown law, and once and for all a new cultural being has begun to exist.

Thought and expression are thus constituted simultaneously when our cultural assets are mobilized in the service of this unknown law, just as our body suddenly lends itself to a new gesture in the acquisition of habit. Speech is a genuine gesture and, just like all gestures, speech too contains its own sense. This is what makes communication possible. In order for me to understand the other person's words, I must “already know” his vocabulary and his syntax. But that does not mean that the words act by arousing “representations” in me, which could be associated with them and which, when taken together, could eventually reproduce in me the speaker's original “representation.” I do not primarily communicate with “representations” or with a thought, but rather with a speaking subject, with a certain style of being, and with the “world” that he aims at. Just as the significative intention that initiated the other person's speech is not an explicit thought, but rather a certain lack that seeks to be fulfilled, so too is my taking up of this intention not an operation of my thought, but rather a synchronic modulation of my own existence, a transformation of my being. We live in a world where speech is already *instituted*. We possess in ourselves already formed significations for all of these banal words [*paroles*]. They only give rise in us to second-order thoughts, which are in turn translated into other words that require no genuine effort of

expression from us, and that will demand no effort of comprehension from our listeners. Thus, language and the comprehension of language seem self-evident. The linguistic and intersubjective world no longer causes us any wonder, we no longer distinguish it from the world itself, and we reflect within a world already spoken and speaking. We become unaware of what is contingent in expression and in communication, either for the child who learns to speak, or for the writer who says and thinks of something for the first time, in short, for those who transform a certain silence into speech. It is, however, clear that constituted speech, such as it plays out in everyday life, assumes that the decisive step of expression has been accomplished. Our view of man will remain superficial so long as we do not return to this origin, so long as we do not rediscover the primordial silence beneath the noise of words, and so long as we do not describe the gesture that breaks this silence. Speech is a gesture, and its signification is a world.

f. The understanding of gestures.

Modern psychology has, of course, shown that the spectator does not look within himself or within his inner experience for the sense of gestures he witnesses.¹⁶ Consider an angry or threatening gesture. In order to understand these gestures, I have no need of recalling the feelings I experienced while I myself performed these same gestures. I have, from the inside, quite a limited knowledge of the gesture of anger, and so an association through resemblance or a reasoning by analogy would be missing a decisive element. And moreover, I do not perceive the anger or the threat as a psychological fact hidden behind the gesture, I read the anger in the gesture. The gesture does not *make me think* of anger, it is the anger itself. And yet, the sense of the gesture is not perceived like, for example, the color of the rug. If it were presented to me as a thing, then it would not be clear why my understanding of gestures should be restricted, for the most part, to human gestures. I do not “understand” the sexual gesture of the dog, and even less that of the beetle or the praying mantis. I do not even understand emotions in primitive people, or in milieus too different from my own. If a child accidentally witnesses a sexual scene, he can understand it without having the experience of desire or the bodily attitudes that it expresses, but if the child had not yet reached the degree of maturity at which this behavior becomes a possibility for him, then the sexual scene will remain merely an unusual and disturbing spectacle, it will not make sense. Of course, knowledge of other people often illuminates self-knowledge; the external spectacle reveals to the child the sense of his own impulses by offering them a goal. But the example would pass by unnoticed if it was not found among the child's internal possibilities. The sense of the gestures is not given but rather understood, which is to say taken up by an act of the spectator. The entire difficulty is to conceive of this act properly and not to confuse it with an epistemic operation. Communication or the understanding of gestures is achieved through the reciprocity between my intentions and the other person's gestures, and between my gestures and the intentions which can be read in the other person's behavior. Everything happens as if the other person's intention inhabited my body, or as if my intentions inhabited his body. The gesture I witness sketches out the first signs of an intentional object. This object becomes present and is fully understood when the powers of my body adjust to it and fit over it. The gesture is in front of

me like a question, it indicates to me specific sensible points in the world and invites me to join it there. Communication is accomplished when my behavior finds in this pathway its own pathway. I confirm the other person, and the other person confirms me.

Here the experience of others, which is distorted by intellectualist analyses, must be restored, just as we will have to restore the perceptual experience of the thing. When I perceive a thing such as a fireplace, it is not the concordance of its various appearances that leads me to believe in the existence of the fireplace as the geometrical plan and common signification of all of these perspectives. On the contrary, I perceive the thing in its own clarity, and this is what gives me the assurance of obtaining an indefinite series of concordant perspectives through the unfolding of perceptual experience. The identity of the thing throughout perceptual experience is merely another aspect of the identity of one's own body throughout the exploratory movements, and is thus of the same nature. Just like the body schema, the fireplace is a system of equivalences that are not grounded upon the recognition of some law, but upon the experience [*l'épreuve*] of a bodily presence. I engage myself with my body among things, they coexist with me insofar as I am an embodied subject, and this life among things has nothing in common with the construction of scientific objects. Similarly, I do not understand the other person's gestures through an act of intellectual interpretation; the communication between consciousnesses is not grounded upon the shared sense of their experiences, rather it grounds them in turn. The movement by which I lend myself to the spectacle must be recognized as irreducible. I join with it in a sort of blind recognition that precedes the definition or intellectual elaboration of the sense. Generation after generation “understand” and accomplish the sexual gestures, such as the caress, prior to the philosopher¹⁷ defining their intellectual signification – which is to enclose the passive body within itself, to sustain the passive body in the sleepy state of pleasure, and to interrupt the incessant movement by which it projects itself into things and toward others. I understand the other person through my body, just as I perceive “things” through my body. The sense of the gesture thus “understood” is not behind the gesture, it merges with the structure of the world that the gesture sketches out and that I take up for myself. The sense of the gesture spreads across the gesture itself – just as the signification of the fireplace in perceptual experience is not beyond the sensible spectacle nor beyond the fireplace itself such as my gaze and my movements find it in the world.

g. [The linguistic gesture.]

The linguistic gesture, like all others, sketches out its own sense. At first this idea is surprising, but we are nevertheless obliged to adopt it if we wish to understand the origin of language, a problem that is still pressing, despite the agreement among psychologists and linguists to deny it in the name of positive science. At first, it seems impossible to allow either words or gestures an immanent signification, because the gesture is limited to indicating a certain relation between man and the perceptible world, because this world is given to the spectator through natural perception, and because the intentional object is hence offered to the observer at the same time as the gesture itself. The verbal gesture, however, intends a mental landscape that is not straightaway given to everyone, and it is precisely its function to communicate this landscape. But culture here offers what nature does not provide. Available significations, namely, previous acts of expression, establish a common world between speaking subjects

to which current and new speech refers, just as the gesture refers to the sensible world. And the sense of the speech is nothing other than the manner in which it handles this linguistic world, or in which it modulates upon this keyboard of acquired significations. I grasp it in an undivided act that is as brief as a cry. Of course, the problem is merely deferred. How are these available significations themselves constituted? Once language is formed, we believe that speech can signify like a gesture against the shared mental background. But do syntactical forms and forms of vocabulary, which are thus presupposed, carry their sense in themselves? We can, for example, see quite clearly what is shared between the gesture and its sense in the expression of emotions and in the emotions themselves: the smile, the relaxed face, and the cheerfulness of the gestures actually contain the rhythm of the action or of this joy as a particular mode of being in the world. And yet, is not the link between the verbal sign and its signification purely accidental, as is attested to by the existence of several languages? And was not the communication of the elements of the language between the “first man who spoke” and the second necessarily of an entirely different kind than communication through gestures?

h. [There are neither any natural signs nor any purely conventional signs.]*

This difference is what we usually express by saying that the emotional gesture and gesticulation are “natural signs,” whereas speech is a “conventional sign.” But conventions are a recent mode of relation between men, they presuppose an earlier means of communication, and language must be put back into this communicative current. If we consider only the conceptual and final sense of words, it is true that the verbal form – with the exception of the inflections – seems arbitrary. This would no longer hold if we took the emotional sense of the word into account, what we have above called its gestural sense, which is essential in poetry, for example. We would then find that words, vowels, and phonemes are so many ways of singing the world, and that they are destined to represent objects, not through an objective resemblance, in the manner imagined by the naïve theory of onomatopoeia, but because they are extracted from them, and literally express their emotional essence. If we could deduct from a vocabulary what was owed to the mechanical laws of phonetics, to the contaminations by foreign languages, to the rationalization of grammarians, and to the imitation of the language itself by itself, we would likely discover a somewhat restricted system of expression at the origin of each language, but this would likely be a system such that, for example, if we use the word “*nuit*” for night, then it would not be arbitrary that we use “*lumière*” for light. The predominance of vowels in one language, of consonants in another, or systems of construction and syntax would not represent so many arbitrary conventions for expressing the same thought, but rather several ways for the human body to celebrate the world and to finally live it. This is why the *full* sense of a language is never translatable into another. We can speak several languages, but one of them always remains the one in which we live. In order to wholly assimilate a language, it would be necessary to take up the world it expresses, and we never belong to two worlds at the same time.¹⁸

If there is a universal thought, we reach it by taking up the effort of expression and communication such as it was attempted by *one* language, by taking up all of the equivocations, all of the shifts in sense out of which a linguistic tradition is made and that measure its power of expression precisely. A conventional algorithm – which, moreover, only has sense in relation to language – will never express

anything other than nature without man. Thus, there are, strictly speaking, no conventional signs and no simple notation of a thought that is pure and clear for itself. There are only words into which the history of an entire language is compressed, and which accomplish communication without any guarantee in the midst of incredible linguistic hazards. If it still seems to us that language is more transparent than music, this is because we remain for the most part within constituted language, we provide ourselves with available significations, and we limit ourselves – like the dictionary – to indicating equivalences between our definitions. The sense of a phrase appears intelligible to us throughout, even detachable from this phrase and defined in an intelligible world, because we presuppose as given all of the participations that it owes to the history of the language and that contribute to determining its sense. In music, however, no vocabulary is presupposed: the sense appears tied to the empirical presence of sounds, and this is why music seems unable to speak. But as we have said the clarity of language is in fact established against an obscure background, and, if we push the research far enough, we find that language itself, in the end, says nothing other than itself, or that its sense is not separable from it. We must, then, seek the first hints of language in the emotional gesticulation by which man superimposes upon the given world the world according to man.

This is completely different from the famous naturalistic conceptions that reduce the artificial sign to the natural sign and attempt to reduce language to the expression of emotions. The artificial sign does not reduce to the natural sign because there are no natural signs for man. Nor do we compromise what is specific to language by bringing language and emotional expressions together, so long as it is true that the emotion, as a variation of our being in the world, is already contingent with regard to the mechanical resources contained in our body, and manifests the same powers of articulating stimuli and situations that are at their height in language. We could only speak of “natural signs” if the anatomical organization of our body made definite gestures correspond to specific “states of consciousness.” But in fact, the gesticulations of anger or love are not the same for a Japanese person and a Western person. More precisely, the difference between gesticulations covers over a difference between the emotions themselves. It is not merely the gesture that is contingent with regard to bodily organization, it is the very manner of meeting the situation and of living it. When angry, the Japanese person smiles, whereas the Westerner turns red and stamps his foot, or even turns pale and speaks with a shrill voice. Having the same organs and the same nervous system is not sufficient for the same emotions to take on the same signs in two different conscious subjects. What matters is the manner in which they make use of their body, the simultaneous articulation of their body and their world in the emotion. The psycho-physical equipment leaves so many possibilities open, and here we see that – just as in the domain of instincts – there is no human nature given once and for all. The use that a man makes of his body is transcendent with regard to that body as a mere biological being. It is no more natural and no less conventional to cry out in anger or to express love through the kiss¹⁹ than it is to call a table a “table.” Just like words, passionate feelings and behaviors are invented. Even the ones that seem inscribed in the human body, such as paternity, are in fact institutions.²⁰ It is impossible to superimpose upon man both a primary layer of behaviors that could be called “natural” and a constructed cultural or spiritual world. For man, everything is constructed and everything is natural, in the sense that there is no single word or behavior that does not owe something to mere biological being – and, at the same time, there is no word or

behavior that does not break free from animal life, that does not deflect vital behaviors from their direction [*sens*] through a sort of *escape* and a genius for ambiguity that might well serve to define man. Already the mere presence of a living being transforms the physical world, makes “food” appear over here and a “hiding place” over there, and gives to “stimuli” a sense that they did not have. This is even more the case for the presence of a man in the animal world. Behaviors create significations that are transcendent in relation to the anatomical structure and yet immanent to the behavior as such, since behavior can be taught and can be understood. We cannot do without this irrational power that creates and communicates significations, and of which speech is merely a particular case.

i. [Transcendence in language.]

What is simply true – and what justifies the special place that is ordinarily accorded language – is that, of all the expressive operations, speech alone is capable of sedimenting and of constituting an intersubjective acquisition. This fact is not explained by observing that speech can be recorded on paper, whereas gestures or behaviors are only transmitted through direct imitation. For music too can be written, and, even though there can be something of a traditional initiation in music – even though it is perhaps impossible to gain access to atonal music without passing through classical music – each artist takes up the task from the beginning, he has a new world to deliver, while in the order of speech, each writer is aware of intending the same world with which other writers were already concerned. Balzac's world and Stendhal's world are not like planets without communication; speech installs in us the idea of truth as the presumptive limit of its effort. Speech forgets itself as being a contingent fact, it relies upon itself and, as we have seen, this gives us the ideal of a thought without speech, whereas the idea of a piece of music without sound is absurd. Even if “thought without speech” is no more than a limit-idea and a bit of an absurdity [*contresens*], even if the sense of a speech act can never in fact be delivered from its inherence in some speech, the fact remains that the expressive operation in the case of speech can be indefinitely reiterated, that one can speak about speech, whereas one cannot paint about painting, and finally that every philosopher has dreamed of a speech that would end everything, whereas the painter or the musician never hopes to exhaust all possible painting or all possible music. There is, then, a privileged place for Reason. But precisely in order to understand it, we must begin by placing thought back among the phenomena of expression.

j. [Confirmation through the modern theory of aphasia.]

This conception of language extends the best and the most current analyses of aphasia, of which we have only begun to draw upon above. In beginning our study, we saw that after an empiricist phase the theory of aphasia (since Pierre Marie)²¹ seemed to pass over to intellectualism, that it implicated the “function of representation” (*Darstellungsfunktion*) or the “categorical” activity²² in linguistic disturbances, and that it based speech upon thought. In fact, the theory does not tend toward a new intellectualism. Whether or not these authors are aware of it, they are attempting to formulate what we will call an existential theory of aphasia, that is, a theory that treats thought and objective language as two manifestations of the fundamental activity by which man projects himself toward a “world.”²³ Consider

the amnesia of color names, for example. Through sorting tests they show that a patient with amnesia has lost the general power of subsuming colors under a category, and they relate the verbal deficiency to this same cause. But if we go back to the concrete descriptions, we notice that the categorial activity, prior to being a thought or a knowledge, is a certain manner of relating to the world, and correlatively is a style or a configuration of experience. For a normal subject, the perception of a pile of color samples organizes itself according to the given instruction: “The colors that belong to the same category as the model stand out from the background of the others”;²⁴ all of the reds, for example, constitute a group and the subject merely has to break apart this group in order to gather together all of the samples that belong to it. For the patient, however, each sample is confined within its individual existence. Against the constitution of a group according to a given principle, the samples present a sort of viscosity or inertia. When two objectively similar colors are presented to the patient, they do not necessarily appear to him as similar. It can happen that the fundamental tone dominates in one, while the degree of light or warmth dominates in the other.²⁵ We can obtain an experience of this sort by placing ourselves in front of a pile of samples with an attitude of passive perception. The identical colors assemble before our eyes, but merely similar colors only establish tentative relations between them. “The pile appears unstable, it shifts, we observe an incessant changing, a sort of battle between several possible groupings of colors according to different points of view.”²⁶ We are reduced to the immediate experience of relations (*Kohärenzerlebnis*, *Erlebnis des Passens*),²⁷ and such is probably the patient's situation. We were wrong to say that he cannot hold himself to a given principle of classification, and that he goes from one to another: in fact, he never adopts a principle at all.²⁸ The disorder affects “the manner in which colors group together for the observer, the manner in which the visual field is articulated from the point of view of colors.”²⁹ It is not merely thought or knowledge, but the very experience of colors that is in question. One could say, to echo another author, that normal experience includes “circles” or “vortices” within which each element is the representative of all the others and carries, as it were, vectors that link it to them. For the patient:

consciousness moves within narrower limits, in smaller and more restricted circles than in the case of normal perception. In this case a movement beginning at the periphery of the vortex would no longer be communicated to its center but would in a manner of speaking remain within the original zone of stimulation or its immediate vicinity. Now comprehensive unities of meaning would no longer be formed within the perceptual world [...]. Each sense impression would still be provided with a vector of meaning, though these vectors would no longer possess a common direction toward very definite main centers but would diverge in far higher degree than is the case in normal perception.³⁰

Such is the disorder of “thought” that is discovered as the basis of amnesia. It clearly has to do less with judgment than with the milieu of experience in which judgment is born, less with spontaneity than with the holds of this spontaneity upon the perceptible world and our power to imagine any intention whatever in the world. In Kantian terms, it affects less the understanding than the productive imagination. The categorial act is thus not an ultimate fact, it is constituted in a certain “attitude” (*Einstellung*). Speech, too, is established upon this attitude, such that there could be no question of basing

language upon pure thought. “Categorical behavior and the possession of meaningful language express one and the same fundamental behavior. Neither could be the cause or the effect of the other.”³¹ First, thought is not an effect of language. It is true that certain patients, incapable of grouping the colors by comparing them to a given sample, succeed at this through the intermediary of language.³² They name the model color, and subsequently bring together all of the samples to which the same name fits, without looking at the model. It is also true that abnormal children classify colors together, and even different colors, if they are taught to designate them by the same name.³³ But these are precisely abnormal procedures; they do not express the essential relation between language and thought, but rather the pathological or accidental relation between a language and a thought equally cut off from their living sense. In fact, many patients are capable of repeating the color names without thereby being able to classify them. In the cases of amnesic aphasia:

it thus cannot be the lack of the word taken in itself that makes the categorical behavior difficult or impossible. The words must have lost something that normally belongs to them and that makes them appropriate for being employed in relation to the categorical behavior.³⁴

What, then, have they lost? Is it the word's notional signification? Must we say that the concept has withdrawn from them and consequently turned thought into the cause of language? But when it loses its sense, the word alters even in its perceptible appearance, it *becomes empty*.³⁵ The patient with amnesia to whom a color name is given, asking him to choose a corresponding sample, repeats the name as if he were expecting something from it. But the name is no longer useful to him, it *says nothing* to him, it is bizarre and absurd, just as names are for us when we have repeated them for too long. Patients for whom the words have lost their sense sometimes preserve, at the highest level, the power of associating ideas.³⁶ The name is thus not detached from previous “associations”; it has altered itself, like an inanimate body. The link from the word to its living sense is not an external link of association; the sense inhabits the word, and language “is not an external accompaniment of intellectual processes.”³⁷ Thus we are clearly led to recognize a gestural or existential signification of speech, as we said above. Language certainly has an interior, but this interior is not a thought closed in upon itself and conscious of itself. What, then, does language express if it does not express thought? It presents, or rather it *is*, the subject's taking up of a position in the world of his significations. The term “world” is here not just a manner of speaking: it means that “mental” or cultural life borrows its structures from natural life and that the thinking subject must be grounded upon the embodied subject. For the speaking subject and for those who listen to him, the phonetic gesture produces a certain structuring of experience, a certain modulation of existence, just as a behavior of my body invests – for me and for others – the objects that surround me with a certain signification.

The sense of the gesture is not contained in the gesture as a physical or physiological phenomenon. The sense of the word is not contained in the word as a sound. Rather, it is the definition of the human body to appropriate, in an indefinite series of discontinuous acts, meaningful cores that transcend and transfigure its natural powers. This act of transcendence is initially found in the acquisition of a behavior, and then in the silent communication of the gesture: the body opens itself to a new behavior

and renders that behavior intelligible to external observers through the same power. A system of definite powers suddenly decenters here and there, breaks apart, and is reorganized under a law that is unknown to the subject or the external observer, and which is revealed to them in this very moment. According to Darwin, for example, the knitting of the eyebrows destined to protect the eye from the sun, and the convergence of the eyes destined to permit clear vision become components of the human act of meditation and signify this act for the spectator. Language, in turn, poses no other problem: the contraction of the throat, the sibilant emission of air between the tongue and the teeth, a certain manner of playing with our body suddenly allows itself to be invested with a *figurative sense* and signifies this externally. This is no more and no less miraculous than the emergence of love from desire, or that of the gesture from the uncoordinated movements at the start of life. For the miracle to happen, the phonetic gesticulation must make use of an alphabet of already acquired significations, and the verbal gesture must be performed in a certain panorama that is shared by the interlocutors, just as the comprehension of other gestures presupposes a perceived world shared by everyone in which the sense of the gesture unfolds and is displayed. But this is not a sufficient condition. If authentic, speech gives rise to a new sense, just as the gesture – if it is an initiating gesture – gives a human sense to the object for the first time. Moreover, significations now acquired must surely have been new significations. Thus, we must recognize as an ultimate fact this open and indefinite power of signifying – that is, of simultaneously grasping and communicating a sense – by which man transcends himself through his body and his speech toward a new behavior, toward others, or toward his own thought.

When these authors attempt to conclude the analysis of aphasia through a general conception of language,³⁸ they can be seen even more clearly abandoning the intellectualist language that they had adopted following Pierre Marie and in reaction to Broca's conceptions. Speech can be said to be neither an “intellectual operation” nor a “motor phenomenon”: it is entirely motricity and entirely intelligence. What confirms speech's inherence in the body is that the affections of language cannot be reduced to a unity, and that the primary disorder affects sometimes the body of the word (the material instrument of verbal expression); sometimes the physiognomy of the word (the verbal intention, this sort of overall plan from which we succeed in saying or in writing a word precisely); sometimes the immediate sense of the word (what the German authors call the “verbal concept”); and finally, sometimes the entire structure of the experience, and not merely of linguistic experiences (as in the case of amnesiac aphasia analyzed above). Speech, then, relies upon a stratification of relatively separable powers. But at the same time, it is impossible to find anywhere a linguistic disorder that would be “purely motor” and that does not, to some extent, affect the sense of language. In pure alexia,³⁹ if the subject can no longer recognize the letters or a word, this is from an absence of the power to articulate the visual givens, to constitute the structure of the word, and to apprehend its visual signification. In motor aphasia, the list of words lost or conserved does not correspond to their objective characteristics (length, complexity), but to their value for the subject: the patient is incapable of pronouncing separately a letter or a word that occurs within a familiar motor sequence due to a lack of the ability to differentiate “figure” and “background” and to confer the value of “figure” freely upon such a word or such a letter. Articulatory and syntactical accuracy are always inversely related, which shows that the articulation of a word is not a simple motor phenomenon and summons the same energies that organize the syntactical order. This is even more the

case when disturbances of verbal intention are at issue, as in literal paraphasia,⁴⁰ in which letters are omitted, moved, or added, and where the rhythm of the word is altered, it is clearly not a case of a destruction of engrams,⁴¹ but rather a leveling out of the figure and the background, or an absence of the power for structuring the word and for grasping its articulatory physiognomy.⁴²

If we wish to summarize these two sets of observations, it must be said that every linguistic operation presupposes the apprehension of a sense, but that the sense here and there is somehow specialized. There are different layers of signification, from the visual signification of the word up to its conceptual signification, passing through the verbal concept. We will never understand these two ideas simultaneously if we continue to oscillate between the notions of “motricity” and “intelligence,” and if we do not discover a third notion that allows them to be integrated: a function, identical at all levels, that would be at work as much in the hidden preparations of speech as in the articulatory phenomena – a function that bears the entire edifice of language, and that nevertheless solidifies into relatively autonomous processes. We will have the opportunity to see this essential power of speech in cases in which neither thought nor motricity are perceptibly affected, and yet in which the “life” of language is altered. [In the case of Schneider], it happens that vocabulary, syntax, and the body of language appear intact, apart from the fact that the principal propositions dominate there. But the patient does not use these materials in the same way as the normal subject. He hardly speaks unless he is questioned, or, if he takes the initiative of a question, he only ever asks stereotypical questions such as those he asks his children each day when they arrive home from school. He never uses language to express a merely possible situation, and false statements (“the sky is black”) are meaningless for him. He can only speak if he has prepared his sentences in advance.⁴³ It cannot be said that language has become automatic for him, there is no sign of a decline of general intelligence, and words are certainly organized through their sense. But this sense is somehow congealed. Schneider never feels the need to speak, his experience never tends toward speech, it never raises a question, and it never ceases to have this sort of evidentness and self-sufficiency of the real that stifles all interrogation, all reference to the possible, all wonder, and all improvisation. By contrast, we catch sight of the essence of normal language: the intention to speak can only be found in an open experience: it appears, as boiling appears in a liquid, when, in the thickness of being, empty zones are constituted and move outward.

From the moment man uses language to establish a living relation with himself or with his contemporaries, language is no longer an instrument, *no longer a means. Rather, it is a manifestation, a revelation of inner being and of the psychical link that unites us to the world and to our fellows.* As much as the patient's language reveals much knowledge, and as much as it is useful for determinate activities, it is nevertheless completely lacking this productivity that makes up the most profound essence of man and that is perhaps revealed in no creation of civilization with as much clarity as it is revealed in the creation of language itself.⁴⁴

By taking up a famous distinction, it might be said that *languages* [*langages*], that is, constituted systems of vocabulary and syntax, or the various empirically existing “means of expression,” are the depository and the sedimentation of acts of *speech* [*parole*], in which the unformulated sense not only

finds the means of expressing itself on the outside, but moreover acquires existence for itself, and is truly created as sense. Or again, the distinction could be made between a *speaking speech* and a *spoken speech*.⁴⁵ In the former, the meaningful intention is in a nascent state. Here existence is polarized into a certain “sense” that cannot be defined by any natural object; existence seeks to meet up with itself beyond being, and this is why it creates speech as the empirical support of its own non-being. Speech is the excess of our existence beyond natural being. But the act of expression constitutes a linguistic and cultural world, it makes that which stretched beyond fall back into being. This results in spoken speech, which enjoys the use of available significations like that of an acquired fortune. From these acquisitions, other authentic acts of expression – those of the writer, the artist, and the philosopher – become possible. This ever-recreated opening in the fullness of being is what conditions the first speech of the child and the speech of the writer, the construction of the word and the construction of concepts. Such is the function revealed through language, which reiterates itself, depends upon itself, or that like a wave gathers itself together and steadies itself in order to once again throw itself beyond itself.

k.[The miracle of expression in language and in the world.]

Even more clearly than our remarks on spatiality and bodily unity, this analysis of speech and expression leads us to recognize the enigmatic nature of one's own body. It is not an assemblage of particles where each one would remain in itself; or again, it is not an intertwining of processes defined once and for all – it is not where it is, it is not what it is – since we see it in itself secreting a “sense” that does not come from nowhere, projecting this sense upon its material surroundings, and communicating it to other embodied subjects. It was always observed that the gesture or speech transfigure the body, but no more was said than that they developed or manifested a different power, such as thought or the soul. It was not seen that, in order to be able to express these, the body must ultimately become the thought or the intention that it signifies to us. It is the body that shows, that speaks, and this is what we have learned in this chapter. Cézanne once said of a portrait:

If I weave around your expression the whole infinite network of little bits of blue and brown that are there, that combine there, I'll get your authentic look on my canvas. [...] And God help them if they can't see how you make a mouth look sad or a cheek smile by joining a green shade to a red one.⁴⁶

This revelation of an immanent or nascent meaning [*sens*] in the living body extends, as we will see, to the entire sensible world, and our gaze, informed by the experience of one's own body, will discover the miracle of expression in all other “objects.” In *Le peau de chagrin*, Balzac describes a “tablecloth white as a bed of freshly-fallen snow, on which the places were laid in orderly array, crowned with honey-coloured rolls.”⁴⁷ And Cézanne concedes:

All my early life I wanted to paint that, the tablecloth of fresh snow ... Now I know that one must want to paint merely: “the places laid in orderly array” and “honey-coloured rolls.” If I paint “crowned” I'm done for ... Do you understand? And if I truthfully balance and relate my places and my rolls as they are in nature, you can be sure that the crowns, the snow, and all the excitement will be there ...⁴⁸

The problem of the world – and to begin with, the problem of one's own body – consists in the fact that *everything resides within the world*.

[The body and Cartesian analysis.]⁴⁹

The Cartesian tradition has taught us to disentangle ourselves from the object: the reflective attitude purifies simultaneously the common notions of body and of soul by defining the body as a sum of parts without an interior and the soul as a being directly and fully present to itself. These corresponding definitions establish a clarity within us and outside of us, namely, the transparency of an object without folds, and the transparency of a subject who is nothing other than what it thinks it is. The object is an object through and through and consciousness is consciousness through and through. There are two, and only two, senses of the word “to exist”: one exists as a thing, or one exists as a consciousness. The experience of one's own body, however, reveals to us an ambiguous mode of existence. If I attempt to conceive of it as a bundle of third person processes – “vision,” “motricity,” “sexuality” – I observe that these “functions” cannot be linked among themselves or to the external world through causal relations. All of them are confusedly taken up and implicated in a single drama. The body, then, is not an object. For the same reason, the consciousness that I have of it is not a thought, that is, I cannot decompose and recompose this consciousness in order to form a clear idea. Its unity is always implicit and confused. It is always something other than what it is: always sexuality at the same time as freedom, always rooted in nature at the very moment it is transformed by culture; it is never self-enclosed but never transcended. Whether it is a question of the other person's body or of my own, I have no other means of knowing the human body than by living it, that is, by taking up for myself the drama that moves through it and by merging with it. Thus, I am my body, at least to the extent that I have an acquisition, and reciprocally my body is something like a natural subject, or a provisional sketch of my total being.

The experience of one's own body, then, is opposed to the reflective movement that disentangles the object from the subject and the subject from the object, and that only gives us thought about the body or the body as an idea, and not the experience of the body or the body in reality. Descartes was well aware of this, for in a famous letter to Elizabeth he distinguishes between the body as it is conceived through its use in life and the body as it is conceived by the understanding.⁵⁰ But for Descartes, this strange knowledge that we have of our body thanks to the mere fact that we are our body remained subordinated to knowledge through ideas because behind man, such as he in fact is, stands God as the rational author of our factual situation. Supported by this transcendent guarantor, Descartes can blandly accept our irrational condition, for we are not the ones required to bear reason and, once we have recognized reason as the foundation of things, all that remains for us is to act and to think in the world.⁵¹ But if our union with the body is substantial, how could we experience a pure soul in ourselves and, from there, accede to an absolute Spirit? Prior to posing this question, let us see clearly all that is implied by the rediscovery of one's own body. It is not merely one object among all others that resists reflection and remains, so to speak, glued to the subject. Obscurity spreads to the perceived world in its entirety.